BUDAPEST, HUNGARY

Hungarian National Gallery: Masterpieces

Twenty paintings of company, separation and the spaces that hold them.



A picnic spreads its participants across a slope. Family portraits gather people closely without making them look in one direction. Historical scenes place bodies in arrangements of authority, injury or collective effort. In this selection, belonging to a group rarely means occupying the same position within it.

The landscapes offer a useful pause from those relations. A road, a clearing or even the open sky can establish the terms on which a figure enters the scene. Across the twenty works, watch the intervals between people as closely as their expressions. A gap, a change of scale or a shared task can explain the grouping more securely than a guessed account of its participants' feelings.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/hungarian-national-gallery

The selection · 20

1. Picnic in May
   Pál Szinyei Merse · 1873
2. Lady in Violet
   Pál Szinyei Merse · 1874
3. The Balloon
   Pál Szinyei Merse · 1878
4. Meadow with Poppies
   Pál Szinyei Merse · 1896
5. Woman with a Birdcage
   József Rippl-Rónai · 1892
6. Self-Portrait in a Brown Hat
   József Rippl-Rónai · 1897
7. On the Hilltop
   Károly Ferenczy · 1901
8. Double Portrait: Béni and Noémi
   Károly Ferenczy · 1908
9. Self-Portrait in the Studio
   Károly Ferenczy · 1903
10. Siblings: The Artist's Children
    Károly Ferenczy · 1911
11. The Magician's Garden
    Lajos Gulácsy · 1906–1907
12. Dante's Meeting with Beatrice
    Lajos Gulácsy · c. 1906
13. The Road to Berzova
    László Paál · 1871
14. Depths of the Forest
    László Paál · 1876
15. The Battlefield of Isaszeg
    Mihály Munkácsy · 1867–1868
16. Before the Collection Box
    Mihály Munkácsy · 1874
17. Dózsa's People
    Viktor Madarász · 1868
18. Ilona Zrínyi before the Investigating Judge
    Viktor Madarász · 1859
19. The Rákóczi March: Study
    Simon Hollósy · 1899
20. Bridge Builders
    Gyula Derkovits · 1932

01 / 20

Picnic in May

Pál Szinyei Merse

1873 · Hungarian National Gallery



Pál Szinyei Merse. Picnic in May. Image credit: Pál Szinyei Merse; Source credit: JAFZGy3-8OmOnw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The white cloth provides a centre without arranging the picnickers in a formal ring. Their scattered positions belong to the slope, while bright dresses and the red parasol distribute attention across grass and shadow. Szinyei Merse gives outdoor company a looseness held together by colour. The people share an occasion without being made to perform one common gesture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1547

02 / 20

Lady in Violet

Pál Szinyei Merse

1874 · Hungarian National Gallery



Pál Szinyei Merse. Lady in Violet. Image credit: Pál Szinyei Merse; Source credit: OAEKWA0OA9AYqQ at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dress occupies a large area, extending the sitter into the foreground through dark folds. Its violet distinguishes her from the landscape's green and gold while maintaining a substantial colour relation with them. Szinyei Merse makes costume a structural part of the portrait. The body is presented through the shape the clothing gives it, not through facial expression alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 5078

03 / 20

The Balloon

Pál Szinyei Merse

1878 · Hungarian National Gallery



Pál Szinyei Merse. The Balloon. Image credit: Pál Szinyei Merse; Source credit: YQGm73WzJ0sNUA at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The strip of land is small, leaving the balloon to occupy a space usually treated as background. Stripes make the rounded envelope readable against blue sky, and the suspended basket emphasises its distance from the ground. Szinyei Merse redistributes the landscape's weight upwards. Open air becomes a place of human occupation rather than merely weather above a scene.

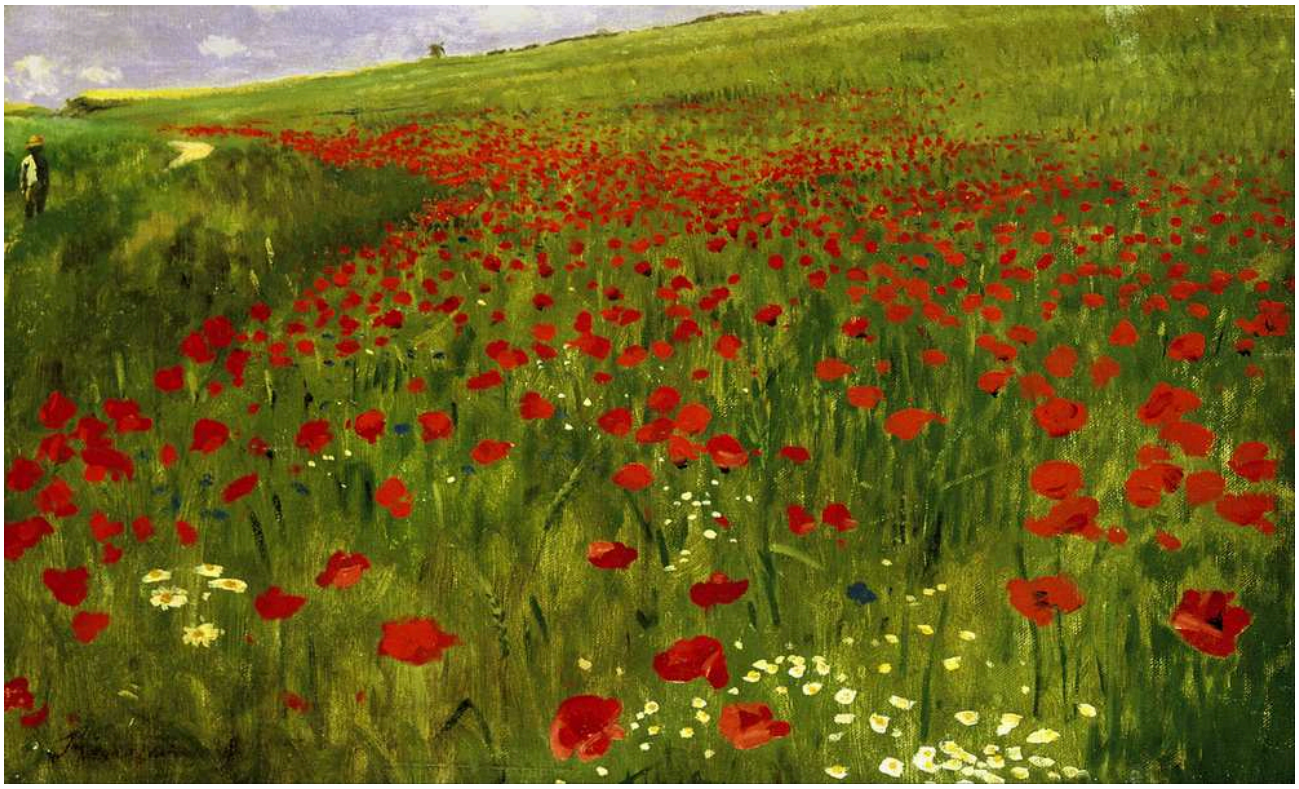
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 4648

04 / 20

Meadow with Poppies

Pál Szinyei Merse

1896 · Hungarian National Gallery



Pál Szinyei Merse. Meadow with Poppies. Image credit: Szinyei Merse, Pál (1845 - 1920) – Painter (Hungarian) Born in Szinyeújfalu. Died in Jernye. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: SwEgfZYCYPZimw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Red marks can be read as separate flowers or as a pattern spreading through green. Szinyei Merse leaves both scales available, while the narrow horizon keeps attention close to the meadow. The picture changes with the kind of looking brought to it: identifying a poppy and registering an extensive flowering surface are related but not identical acts.

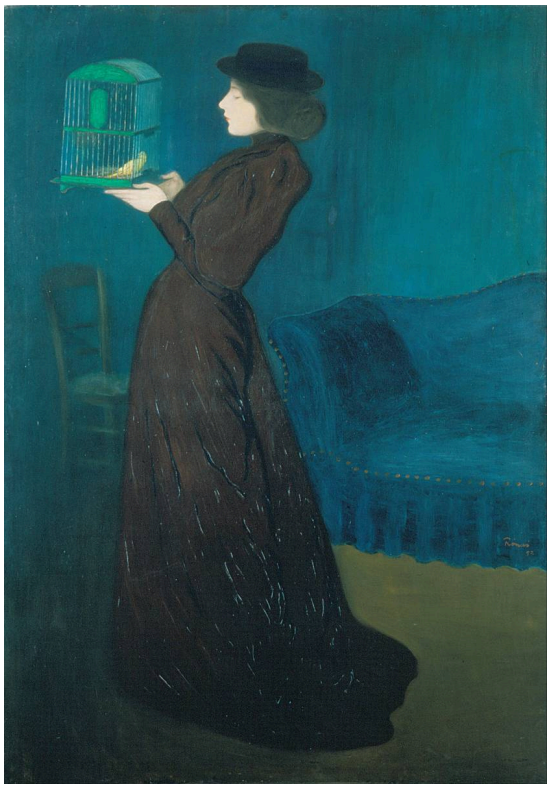
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3474

05 / 20

Woman with a Birdcage

József Rippl-Rónai

1892 · Hungarian National Gallery



József Rippl-Rónai. Woman with a Birdcage. Image credit: József Rippl-Rónai; Source credit: -QHtiPUw_NMxsg at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The small cage interrupts the length of the dark profile. Rippl-Rónai keeps the surrounding blue-green interior simple enough for that held object to alter the whole arrangement. A slight domestic action therefore acquires structural importance. The figure and cage do not need an explanatory anecdote to establish a relation of vertical body, hands and suspended form.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: FK1385

06 / 20

Self-Portrait in a Brown Hat

József Rippl-Rónai

1897 · Hungarian National Gallery



József Rippl-Rónai. Self-Portrait in a brown hat. Image credit: Rippl-Rónai, József (1861 - 1927) – Painter (Hungarian) Born in Kaposvár. Died in Kaposvár. Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: YAG0kbOemTb_SQ at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Pictures fill the wall around the artist, placing his likeness within a visible professional setting. The grey coat provides a broad foreground area beneath the hat and turned face. Rippl-Rónai chooses a crowded frame for self-presentation. The surrounding works are part of that choice, rather than neutral background information accidentally included with the sitter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 57.60 T

07 / 20

On the Hilltop

Károly Ferenczy

1901 · Hungarian National Gallery



Károly Ferenczy. On the Hill-top. Image credit: Károly Ferenczy; Source credit: A Ferenczy Károly-kiállítás készítőinek blogja Pic Source of painting properties: Fine Arts in Hungary. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The small dark figure stands at a junction between shaded vegetation and clear sky. Ferenczy allows the landscape to outweigh the person while retaining a distinct human position inside it. The opening around the body matters as much as the body itself. Scale makes the person a measure of the view without turning that person into its owner.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Double Portrait: Béni and Noémi

Károly Ferenczy

1908 · Hungarian National Gallery



Károly Ferenczy. Double Portrait (Béni and Noémi). Image credit: Károly Ferenczy; Source credit: Photo by User:Yelkrokoyade Source of painting properties: Fine arts in Hungary. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A raised arm and joined hands establish different kinds of posture within the shared blue surround. Ferenczy gives the sitters a relation without requiring mirrored gestures. The double portrait can be read across the space between them as well as face by face. Their unequal actions keep the grouping from becoming two equivalent likenesses in one frame.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Self-Portrait in the Studio

Károly Ferenczy

1903 · Hungarian National Gallery



Károly Ferenczy. Self-portrait (in the Atelier). Image credit: Károly Ferenczy; Source credit: Fine Arts in Hungary:. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The raised hand carries attention towards something outside the visible edge. Painting equipment identifies the setting, but the working gesture prevents the artist from becoming a wholly detached sitter. Ferenczy presents a moment of consideration whose object remains beyond the frame. The self-portrait includes an activity without completing its account for the viewer.

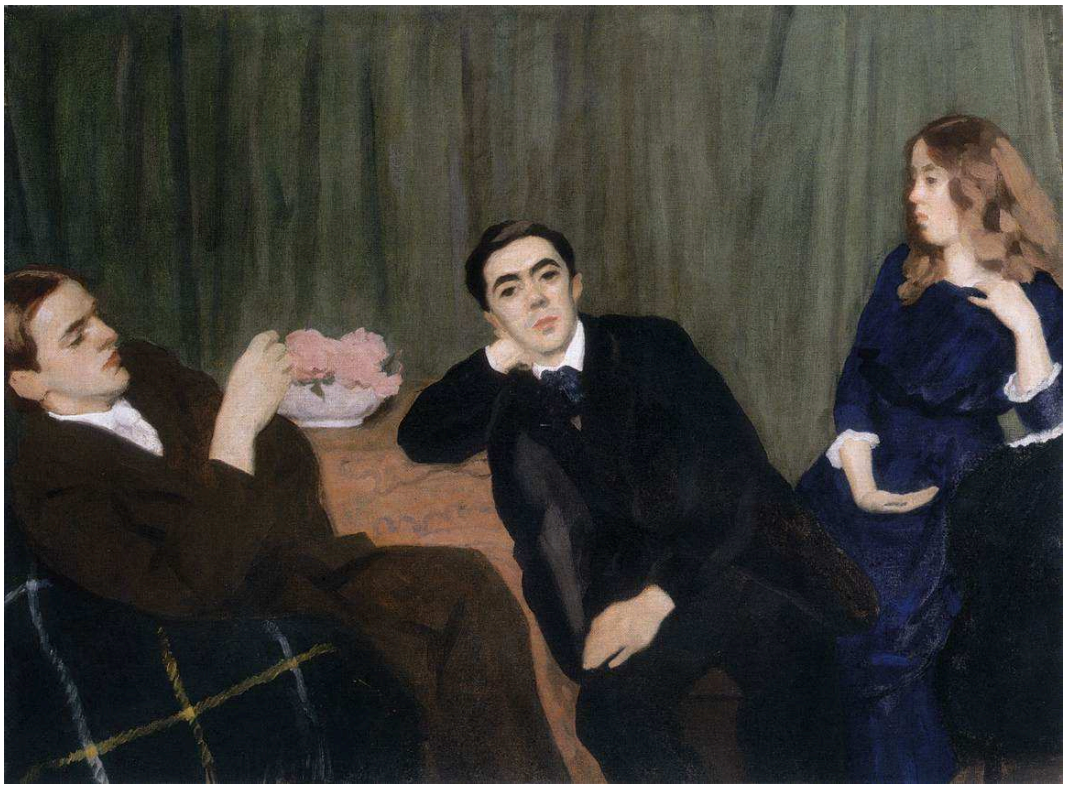
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2473

10 / 20

Siblings: The Artist's Children

Károly Ferenczy

1911 · Hungarian National Gallery



Károly Ferenczy. Siblings (The Artist's Children). Image credit: Károly Ferenczy; Source credit: Fine Arts in Hungary:. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The three figures share a close setting but turn in different directions. Flowers and curtain help organise them without enforcing a uniform outward gaze. Ferenczy makes kinship compatible with separate attention. The portrait records a grouping whose members remain individuals, rather than using family resemblance as a reason to repeat the same pose.

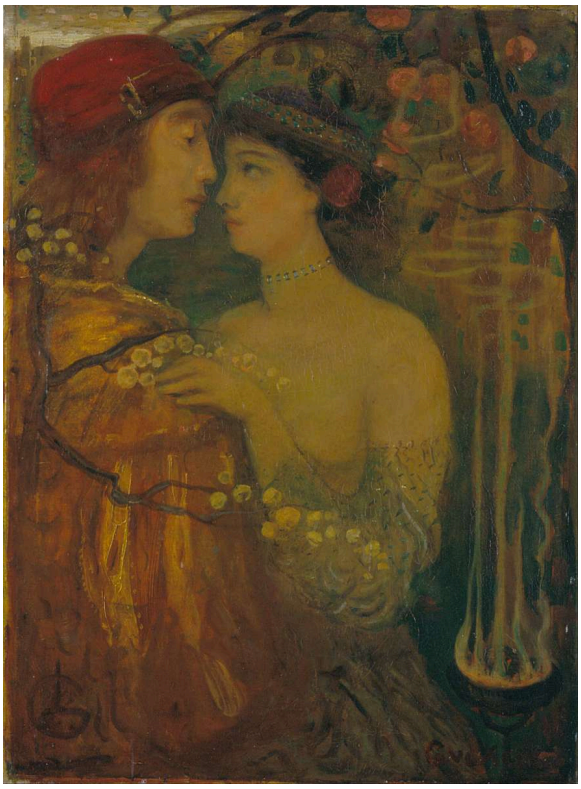
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 6336

11 / 20

The Magician's Garden

Lajos Gulácsy

1906–1907 · Hungarian National Gallery



Lajos Gulácsy. The garden of the magician. Image credit: Lajos Gulácsy; Source credit: 5QESAciqYHxpww at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The heads nearly meet across a narrow interval, concentrating the encounter within a richly patterned setting. Gulácsy withholds the ordinary spatial clues that would make the garden easy to map. Costume and gesture must carry the relation between the figures. Their closeness is clear even when the place and circumstances remain deliberately uncertain.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: FK10197

12 / 20

Dante's Meeting with Beatrice

Lajos Gulácsy

c. 1906 · Hungarian National Gallery



Lajos Gulácsy. Dante's Meeting with Beatrice. Image credit: Lajos Gulácsy; Source credit: Fine Arts in Hungary:. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The red-clad figure is separated from the approaching women by a path and intervening trees. Gulácsy gives the literary meeting an interval before contact. The title tells us what encounter to anticipate, while the spacing makes anticipation visible. Recognition belongs to the distance between figures as much as to any individual face.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: FK302

13 / 20

The Road to Berzova

László Paál

1871 · Hungarian National Gallery



László Paál. The Road to Berzova. Image credit: László Paál; Source credit: Self-scanned. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The reddish road connects houses, trees and scattered figures without requiring a grand prospect beyond them. Paál lets an ordinary route organise the village landscape. Warm ground and upright autumn trees offer different directions for the eye. Their relation provides depth and continuity where a more spectacular subject might have supplied an immediate focal point.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2230

14 / 20

Depths of the Forest

László Paál

1876 · Hungarian National Gallery



László Paál. Depths of the Forest. Image credit: László Paál; Source credit: https://www.hung-art.hu/kep/p/paal/muvek/1875-78/erdomelz.jpg. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Tall trunks enclose a pale opening, making the woods resemble an interior with a distant source of light. Paál's repeated verticals establish order without regularising every tree. Uneven growth and dark foliage retain their material differences. The way through the forest is suggested by the opening, but the enclosing forms continue to occupy most of the view.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: FK1819

15 / 20

The Battlefield of Isaszeg

Mihály Munkácsy

1867–1868 · Hungarian National Gallery



Mihály Munkácsy. The Battlefield of Isaszeg. Image credit: Mihály Munkácsy; Source credit: Munkácsy Foundation Info Pic. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The extensive ground exceeds any one action among its small figures and animals. Munkácsy disperses the event across a darkening landscape rather than concentrating it in a dominant heroic body. Broken light reveals activity without making the whole field immediately comprehensible. The scene's scale leaves human events difficult to gather into a single controlled account.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1821

16 / 20

Before the Collection Box

Mihály Munkácsy

1874 · Hungarian National Gallery



Mihály Munkácsy. In front of the Collecting Box. Image credit: Mihály Munkácsy; Source credit: https://mng.hu/mutargyak/persely-elott/. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

An extended hand connects the woman to the wall-mounted box. Munkácsy isolates that small action in a dim interior, using light on face and clothing to maintain its visibility. The gesture gives enough information to establish a donation without disclosing a motive. Private intention remains distinct from the public act the painting can show.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 7022

17 / 20

Dózsa's People

Viktor Madarász

1868 · Hungarian National Gallery



Viktor Madarász. Dózsa's People. Image credit: Viktor Madarász; Source credit: Hungarian National Gallery Info Pic. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The raised body and tall support concentrate the surrounding figures' effort. Bent limbs, cloth and lifted arms make handling a body visibly difficult. Madarász gives historical suffering a physical structure before the participants are individually identified. The group is joined by the demands of its action rather than by a uniform expression assigned to every face.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 54.324

18 / 20

Ilona Zrínyi before the Investigating Judge

Viktor Madarász

1859 · Hungarian National Gallery



Viktor Madarász. Ilona Zrínyi before the Investigating Judge. Image credit: Viktor Madarász; Source credit: Fine Arts in Hungary:. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The standing woman and child face men who possess seats, arms and the room's ceremonial apparatus. Madarász makes institutional power a distribution of space and objects, not merely a facial expression. The pair's upright position distinguishes them while exposing their unequal situation. Their side of the encounter has fewer means of occupying the room.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2805

19 / 20

The Rákóczi March: Study

Simon Hollósy

1899 · Hungarian National Gallery



Simon Hollósy. "The Rákóczi-March" (Study). Image credit: Simon Hollósy; Source credit: Fine Arts in Hungary: More info: [1]. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Some faces emerge from the advancing crowd while others remain rough marks. Hollósy's study allows collective movement to become readable before every participant has been fixed. The uneven degree of finish is therefore informative. It shows the gathering arrangement in progress rather than giving each individual an equal claim on the surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: FK8032

20 / 20

Bridge Builders

Gyula Derkovits

1932 · Hungarian National Gallery



Gyula Derkovits. Bridge Builders. Image credit: Gyula Derkovits; Source credit: Fine Arts in Hungary:. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Pale beams cut across orange-clad workers above blue water. Derkovits makes the people and their construction share a compressed network of edges. Labour cannot be separated cleanly from the structure because the same divisions organise both. The bridge is neither a completed backdrop nor an isolated engineering object; it is the condition of the workers' visible activity.

Object source · Open artwork

Read the group, then the individual

Compare the family portraits with the public historical scenes. Notice which differences of gesture are preserved and which relations are imposed by the setting. The guide follows recorded collection works; current display and access should be checked separately before a visit.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed discusses the organization of figures, masses and colour in terms that can be tested against these pictures. Compare his advice with Ferenczy’s portraits and Derkovits’s much more compressed arrangement of workers and steel.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12